To his former history professor at the ETH, Alfred Stern, he wrote, “1 am beside myself with joy about [this teaching job], because today I received the news that everything has been definitely arranged. 1 have not the slightest idea as to who might be the humanitarian who recommended me there, because from what 1 have been told, l am not in the good books of any of my former teachers.” The job in Winterthur, followed in autumn 1901 by another temporary high school teaching job in Schaffhausen, Switzerland, and then in June 1902 by a job as “technical expert third class” in the Swiss Patent Office in Bern, gave him independence and stability.

Despite continued turbulence in his personal life (long separations from Mileva; an illegitimate child with Mileva in 1902, whom they seem to have put up for adoption, perhaps to protect Einstein’s career possibilities in staid Switzerland; his marriage to Mileva a year later in spite of his parents’ violent opposition), Einstein maintained an optimistic spirit and remained clear-headed enough to think, and think deeply about physics: From 1901 through 1904 he seasoned his powers as a physicist by theoretical research on the nature of the forces between molecules in liquids, such as water, and in metals, and research on the nature of heat. His new insights, which were substantial, were published in a sequence of five articles in the most prestigious physics journal of the early 1900s: the *Annalen der Physik.*

The patent office job in Bern was well suited to seasoning Einstein’s powers. On the job he was challenged to figure out whether the inventions submitted would work—often a delightful task, and one that sharpened his mind. And the job left free half his waking hours and all weekend. Most of these he spent studying and thinking about physics, often in the midst of family chaos.

His ability to concentrate despite distractions was described by a student, who visited him at home several years after his marriage to Mileva: “He was sitting in his study in front of a heap of papers covered with mathematical formulas. Writing with his right hand and holding his younger son in his left, he kept replying to questions from his elder son Albert who was playing with his bricks. With the words, ‘Wait a minute, I’ve nearly finished,’ he gave me the children to look after for a few moments and went on working.”

In Bern, Einstein was isolated from other physicists (though he did have a few close non-physicist friends with whom he could discuss science and philosophy). For most physicists, such isolation would be disastrous. Most